

FUNDAMENTAL FIGHTER

Qazi Hussain Ahmad

AMIR, Jamaat-e-Islami

The hardline Pakhtun 'amir' (or head) of the Jamaat-e-Islami Qazi Hussain Ahmad has remained steadfast in his opposition to General Musharraf after initially allying—along with the religious alliance, the Muttaheda Majlis-e-Amal (MMA)—with the General to constitutionally legitimise his takeover in 1999. His often-angry rhetoric has been fuelled not only by a sense of betrayal by Musharraf but by his strongly-felt opposition to Musharraf's "pro-American" policies especially in Afghanistan and the tribal areas. He has also been severely critical of Musharraf's abandoning of the jihadi forces in Kashmir. The Jamaat may not have the electoral muscle of Fazlur Rahman's larger Jamiat-e-Ulema-Islam, but has a strong, committed cadre of workers who can be counted upon for street power. Qazi Hussain, along with the other religious parties, has so far been marginal in an anti-Musharraf movement led by liberals and secular moderates, but would be looking to gain political space with the removal of Musharraf. Any broad alliance against the President, he believes, would be useful for the Jamaat in the long run.

THE HARDLINE HUSSAIN HAS REMAINED STEADFAST IN OPPOSING THE GENERAL USING STREET POWER TO MOBILISE DISSENT.

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MUZZLE POWER

Mir Shakilur Rahman

OWNER, Jang Group of Newspapers

Nobody would normally ever accuse Mir Shakilur Rahman, the owner of the Jang Group of Newspapers—which publishes Pakistan's largest Urdu newspaper and the Geo Television empire—of being a symbol of resistance. Media activists have often griped that the Jang Group usually shows the least backbone in the face of government, corporate or political pressure. But as head of the largest television network hit by the government-ordered cable blackout, Rahman does represent those within the media still refusing to toe the Government line and accept the new curbs. Geo News continues to broadcast out of studios in Dubai despite reports of pressure on the UAE Government to curtail its freedom. Expatriates and those within Pakistan with access to direct satellite reception and Internet streaming can see its regular appeals against the Government crackdown. Rahman has claimed threats to his safety and with mounting commercial losses in tens of crores—Geo's sports channel, Geo Super, had bought rights for the current India-Pakistan cricket series but has been unable to show it—it remains to be seen how far his resistance can sustain.

AS HEAD OF THE LARGEST TV NETWORK, HE REPRESENTS THOSE WITHIN THE MEDIA WHO REFUSE TO TOE THE GOVERNMENT LINE AND ACCEPT CURBS.

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